

NATIONAL

AFFAIRS

HOW THE PENTAGON HIDES ITS SECRET SPENDING

WASHINGTON, D.C.

THE WAR THAT BEGAN WHEN World War II ended is over. But the dinosaurs of the cold war still live among us. And the greatest of them remains hidden within the walls of the Pentagon.

The Pentagon has a secret stash — they call it the black budget — that costs us \$100 million a day. This money is still being spent on the weapons to fight the cold war, and the Third World War, and World War IV.

The black budget funds every program the president of the United States, the secretary of defense and the director of central intelligence want to keep hidden from public view. This money is erased from the public ledger. The secret weapons, secret wars and secret policies it pays for are shielded from public debate. In the past three years, \$100 billion has disappeared into the Pentagon's classified cache.

The money to run America's eleven intelligence agencies — including the CIA and the far larger National Security Agency (NSA), which taps world telecommunications, and National Reconnaissance Office (NRO), which operates spy satellites — has always been hidden in the Pentagon's budget. But something new transformed the black budget as the Eighties began and Ronald Reagan came to power. A White House obsessed with secrecy began to conceal the costs of many of its most expensive weapons, enshrouding them in the deep cover once reserved for espionage. The black budget soon exploded. By 1990 it quadrupled in size, reaching roughly \$36 billion a year.

The Pentagon keeps this money hidden by keeping two sets of books: one for the general public, one for the generals. Hundreds of black programs are concealed in the public budget it submits to Congress, camouflaged under false names, their costs deleted, their goals dis-

guised. Code words and blank spaces stand where facts and figures should be. The Pentagon simply stamps a secret code on the price of a bomber, a missile or a spy satellite, and open debate ceases. In addition, the Pentagon pads seemingly unclassified programs with billions intended for black projects. In short, the Pentagon's budget is a false document, an elaborate cover story.

Behind this shield of secrecy, we are wasting fortunes perfecting plans for nuclear war, building nuclear bombers that cannot be used, launching spy satellites that fall from the sky, conducting self-destructive covert operations against enemies both real and imagined, running guns and missiles to warring tribes ten thousand miles from home.

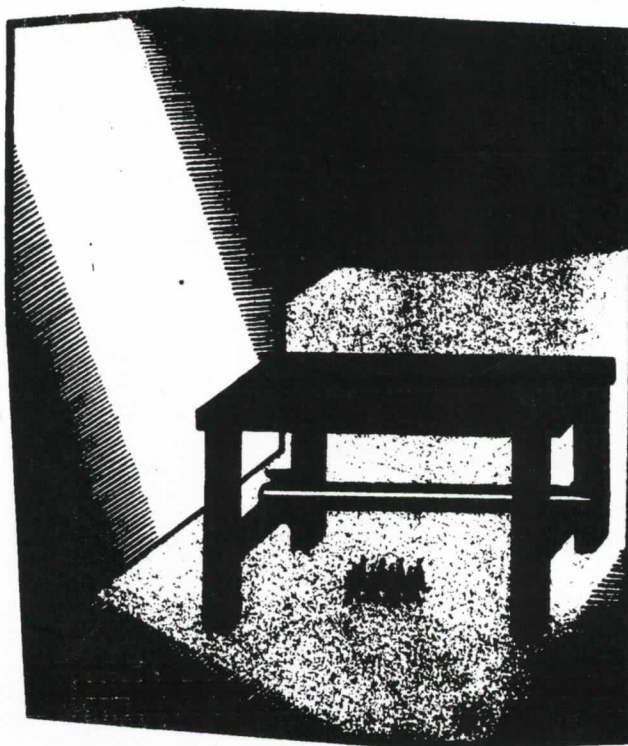
Some of the programs that have been funded by the black budget might make sense if the government explained them. Others might not. You might question the wisdom of a \$22 billion satellite system designed to help win a nuclear war. This program — which has been partially declassified, so I can write about it and you can read about it without breaking the laws of national security — is the Military Strategic and Tactical Relay system: MILSTAR.

MILSTAR IS SUPPOSED TO BE THE MILITARY's global switchboard for World War III. It is to endure that war and stand ready, long after the White House and the Pentagon have been reduced to rubble, to help fight World War IV. Strange as it may sound, that remains the nation's strategy: to fight and win a six-month nuclear war, and to be ready to strike and win again when the next war erupts. And MILSTAR is to be the central nervous system for those wars, a space-based brain to control the immense brawn of the American nuclear arsenal.

In the Pentagon's vision of nuclear victory, shaped by dozens of technologies funded by the black budget, computers run a war no human mind could control.

Robot soldiers stalk radioactive battlegrounds. Generals speed down interstates in lead-lined tractor-trailers, ordering warheads fired from faraway silos. To realize this vision, billions of black dollars a year have been spent on microcircuitry, silicon chips, exotic composite carbons, satellites, missiles and bombers — all immensely costly, technologically exquisite and utterly useless unless the air-raid sirens start howling.

The success of this vision depends on MILSTAR. Imagine it as a military radio and television network whose satellites, broadcast towers, antennas, receivers and state-of-the-art control rooms will be placed strategically in space, around the earth and under the seas. It is far more elaborate than the patchwork that brought live



B Y T I M W E I N E R

ILLUSTRATION BY BRIAN CRONIN

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broadcasts of the Olympics to millions of people in 1988. This network would bring us a far bigger spectacle.

Throughout the Nineties, as many as nine MILSTAR satellites, each costing about \$1 billion, are scheduled to be launched. Once safely in orbit, 22,300 miles from earth, they will be electronically linked with one another, with intelligence satellites and sensors in space and with computer terminals on earth. The Pentagon wants to build more than 3000 of these MILSTAR terminals, each at a cost of at least \$1 million. The president's doomsday airplane, the flying Oval Office that would carry him away from Washington in a crisis, will have one. So will his black stretch limo. So will each of the fifty or so subterranean bunkers across the country where he and his top advisors can hunker down when the war comes.

MILSTAR is supposed to connect the president and his generals to the soldiers with their fingers on the nuclear trigger. The nuclear-war commanders will be hiding underground, hidden underwater in nuclear submarines and hurled aloft in airborne command posts. And some will hurtle down the interstates in those lead-lined trucks. Each of these convoys will be led by a brigadier general with the authority to give the go codes to nuclear-missile and -bomber crews.

The road warriors will run computerized command centers inside the ordinary-looking tractor-trailers. Each will have a MILSTAR terminal, arrayed with a transmitter, receiver and antenna contained in a satellite dish the size of a trash-can lid. The Pentagon has made a multibillion-dollar investment in black programs to create mobile command posts such as these, the idea being that a moving target is harder for the Soviets to hit. Much remains classified about the tractor-trailers, an \$85-million-a-year black program code-named Island Sun – such as where the trucks plan to refuel or change a flat in a nuclear war. But the mission of these tiny Pentagons is clear: to coordinate the nation's nuclear forces.

Thousands of soldiers and civilians huddled underground, headed down the highways, out at sea and in the air will need lines to MILSTAR, to serve as human adjuncts to the computer software of the global war-fighting system. As the war explodes, the satellites must help the software coordinate the hardware of the nation's 23,000 nuclear warheads. Through it all, as the enemy's warheads destroy great cities and isolated military outposts, MILSTAR is to keep the channels of nuclear command flowing. Its satellites are to elude Soviet attack by maneuvering in space, outwitting efforts to jam its signals and piercing the ferocious electronic static of nuclear war. Should political control collapse while the war continues, with soldiers and seamen fighting to the last warhead, MILSTAR is supposed to carry on regardless. Its satellites are designed to stay in orbit, to keep transmitting and relaying, without a human mind to direct them, until the final missile screams across the sky.

That's the plan: to create a network that will force all the elements of nuclear-war fighting – command deci-

sions, weapons control, wartime communications and battlefield intelligence – into a web that will withstand an attack by thousands of Soviet nuclear warheads. MILSTAR is supposed to be that seamless system of command and control.

It is not. That system has not been built and never will be. The reason has little to do with a lack of funds, or a lack of will to build it. The money is being spent; the strategy is already set. The system has not been built because no one has the slightest idea how to do it. The challenge has confounded the best and brightest minds in the military for more than thirty years.

MILSTAR EXISTS BECAUSE THE NUCLEAR STRATEGISTS who came to power with President Reagan truly believed the United States could win the Big One. "The United States may have no practical alternative to waging a nuclear war," wrote Colin Gray,

an influential member of Reagan's brain trust. And if we mustered the will to fight, victory was ours, Gray declared. "The United States should plan to defeat the Soviet Union and to do so at a cost that would not prohibit U.S. recovery," he wrote. His ballpark estimate of the cost: 20 million American dead.

The band of true believers drew up a secret decree for Reagan to sign in October 1981. National Security Decision Directive 13 called for the creation of a new command-and-control system for nuclear war, a system that

could do what their war-fighting rhetoric demanded. The new doctrine said the United States had to be able to fight the Soviets with nuclear weapons for up to six months, force the Soviets to surrender and, at the end of the war, still control a reserve of nuclear forces large enough to enable us to fight again. It said that "the United States must prevail" in a nuclear war against the Soviets. The Reaganites wanted to win.

To achieve that goal, the Pentagon needed MILSTAR. It knew its crazy quilt of wartime communications systems would not work in a nuclear firestorm. Tens of billions of black dollars and hundreds of thousands of intellects had been fused into immensely complicated systems for running a nuclear war – warning radars and sensors and satellites, war rooms and command centers and supercomputers, the safety catch and the trigger for tens of thousands of nuclear warheads. But all the money and all the minds in America had never created a system that could control our nuclear arsenal in a war. What we had instead was "an enormously complex but stupid organism," as Paul Bracken, a leading nuclear-war analyst, calls it. The system was a brontosaurus – a beast with far more brawn than brains.

The Pentagon wanted a new system, one smart and strong enough to endure the war it envisioned. "The people on the right wanted a win-the-war policy," says Bruce Blair, a former nuclear-missile trigger man who conducted an unprecedented study of the Pentagon's nuclear-war plans a few years ago. "So money was siphoned off from ten good, solid, less ambitious programs to pay for MILSTAR."

But some elemental problems cropped up. For example, 120,000 people on some 50 American bases and 160 foreign posts have direct responsibility for carrying out the nuclear-war plan. Tens of thousands of them must communicate through MILSTAR at once in a nuclear crisis. Can MILSTAR cope with life during wartime? It

seems unlikely. Each MILSTAR satellite can handle no more than 15 connections at once. The 16th caller will get a busy signal. If the Pentagon prudently decides to keep two of the nine satellites on earth as spares, as it probably will, that means MILSTAR could handle barely more than 100 urgent demands at a time.

More importantly, things go wrong with complex systems. The more complex they are, the more can go wrong. If there is a lesson to be learned from *Challenger* and Chernobyl, it is that. But the nuclear network under MILSTAR would weaken the only reliable safety catch on the trigger of nuclear weaponry: the human mind.

The computerized nuclear-war technologies incorporated into MILSTAR turn the execution of war strategy into a preprogrammed drill. They take humans out of the loop. "No human being can enter the real-time decision-making loop and control the system," Jacob Gilstein, a former Pentagon weapons wizard, testified before Congress. "It has to be preprogrammed with logic so the computer can make the decision and run the game." As MILSTAR took shape, George Heilmeyer, a former director of the Pentagon's Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), told Congress: "Human limitations in formulating and communicating demands [are] a central difficulty" in executing nuclear commands.

DARPA – the Pentagon's in-house venture-capital firm – insists that the solution to the human problem is obvious. The answer is thinking machines that can pull rank over privates and generals alike in a nuclear war. DARPA says it is writing computer programs to "relieve military personnel in complex decision-making tasks [that are] dangerous or rapidly changing." The software will give nuclear-weapons systems, such as the black budget's Advanced Cruise Missile (ACM), "human-like capabilities to sense, reason, plan and navigate," another former DARPA director, Robert Cooper, has told Congress. DARPA has been working for years to build computerized robots for World War III: "hexapods," with the agility and speed of a tank; "quadrupeds" that gallop and trot; and "walking vehicles" with hands and fingers. The walking vehicle would be the perfect soldier for nuclear war, an android that obeys orders "but does not generate discourse" – no back talk, no balking as it fights to the finish in "an enhanced nuclear environment," the Pentagon's polite phrase for a lethally radioactive battlefield.

The MILSTAR network is to date the highest expression of this kind of thinking. It was intended as a technological solution to a seemingly impossible problem: How do you fight a nuclear war? But the question remains: Can MILSTAR survive a nuclear war four or five or six months long?

"The idea of having it run safely at 120 days strikes me as insane," says Bracken, a Yale professor who has studied these issues for nearly twenty years. "It is a waste of money to spend money on protracted nuclear war."

Ashton Carter, once a ranking Pentagon systems analyst and now a professor of public policy at Harvard's Kennedy School of Government, says MILSTAR is "a very complicated system that's prone to failure."

"No command-and-control system can be expected to do the job it's supposed to do," he says. "It's in the nature of the beast – fighting a war we've never waged, in circumstances we can't foresee, on a time line dictated by technology and weapons, not human decisions. . . . The question is whether the system can survive for a day, not six months."

The Pentagon created MILSTAR in the hope of a better Armageddon, a more efficient, more sophisticated nuclear war. This vision is a delusion. We pursue it even as the rationale for nuclear warfare disappears, as the enemy we would fight turns its back on the battlefield. The

Lead-lined tractor-trailers – each a tiny Pentagon – will hurtle down interstates, but where will they change a flat during a nuclear war?

TIM WEINER is a Washington correspondent for the *Philadelphia Inquirer*. His work on the black budget won the Pulitzer Prize for national reporting in 1988. This article is adapted from his book *Blank Check: The Pentagon's Black Budget*, to be published by Warner Books in September.

idea behind MILSTAR strikes some people well versed in nuclear-war plans as utterly mad, the cost unsupportable, the secrecy undemocratic. Yet it remains difficult to debate the idea openly. It remains part of the closed world of the black budget.

BRUCE BLAIR, THE FORMER NUCLEAR TRIGGER MAN, HAS thought a lot about the unthinkable. Now forty-two, Blair served as a missile-launch-control officer – the man in the bunker with his finger on the button – in the early Seventies. He went on to join the Strategic Air Command (SAC), the air-force elite responsible for nuclear-war plans and actions. He served aboard SAC's Looking Glass, an airborne command post that becomes a nuclear-war nerve center if SAC's headquarters in Omaha, Nebraska, are nuked. The experience sparked a chain of thoughts. Blair has spent the past decade engrossed in the nation's war plans and, increasingly, in the secrecy that sustains them.

When he left the air force, Blair went to Yale, earned a graduate degree and was hired by an arm of Congress, the Office of Technology Assessment. In the early Eighties he was commissioned to study the Pentagon's nuclear-war plans. Blair became one of the few outsiders ever to see the entire Single Integrated Operational Plan, the Pentagon's blueprint for nuclear war. For two years he saw the nerves, muscles and bones of the nation's nuclear forces laid bare.

Blair's study terrified those who saw it. He seems to have concluded that the Pentagon's command-and-control procedures may actually increase the risk of a conventional crisis escalating into nuclear war. But we will never know exactly what he learned. His work was banned and burned. The Pentagon seized it, stamped it with the highest security classification in the government and destroyed all but a few copies. The clearance to read Blair's report – now classified SINGLE INTEGRATED OPERATIONAL PLAN EXTREMELY SENSITIVE INFORMATION – was restricted to four people: the president, the secretary and the deputy secretary of defense, and the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Now, Congress commissioned this work. But Congress can't see Blair's study. Blair can't see Blair's study. And only three people at the Pentagon are authorized to see Blair's study.

The burning of Blair's work was a case of classification gone wild. It has stifled informed discussion of a central issue of military strategy: the control of nuclear weaponry in crisis and in war. George Orwell wrote in 1984 that freedom is the ability to say that two plus two makes four. Blair put two and two together. The Pentagon forbade him to say four. Blair is forever prohibited from discussing details of his censored work. But he can discuss the meaning of MILSTAR and the political climate in which his study was suppressed.

"If MILSTAR is dedicated to protracted nuclear-war fighting, then all democratic debate on the traditional objectives of defense has been muted – and that's wrong," says Blair. "By hiding the specific means to goals like MILSTAR, you're hiding the goals themselves. That's sabotaging our form of government."

Over the years the secrecy of nuclear weapons has defied democratic decision making. "Part of the story of black programs is this loss of faith in the democratic system, the adversarial system, to produce consensus on weapons programs," Blair says. "Taking things black re-

lieves the pressure of give-and-take. You don't have this messy business of democratic debate."

"The black programs are a travesty of our political system," says Blair. "What it means is that nuclear-weapons decisions, decisions that have always eluded democratic controls, are now being delegated to a small, inside group. And we can't delegate decisions on national goals and objectives to a few insiders. . . . It leads to tremendous distortion in the public debate and, potentially, a grave misallocation of resources."

Just how grave remains to be seen. The rise of real debate about MILSTAR in recent months has matched the fall of the black veil that surrounded it. The Pentagon wants more than \$1 billion for MILSTAR in the coming year. But the system makes no sense in a world turning away from nuclear confrontation.

The declassification of MILSTAR's mission and cost has made it a matter of controversy in Congress. This year, for the first time, there is a real chance that Congress will kill MILSTAR, saving at least \$15 billion and sending a clear signal that the United States is stepping back from the notion of winning a nuclear war. MILSTAR's fate will not be resolved until the fall, when the first post-cold-war Pentagon budget emerges from Congress.

The fact is that MILSTAR's billions represent only a small down payment on a military system that could

endure a nuclear war. No one knows if MILSTAR will work, and no one will until a nuclear war erupts.

THE POLITICAL SYSTEM CAN OCCASIONALLY PROVIDE partial answers to the questions about what secret weapons cost and whether they work. This is the case with another once-black, now partially declassified nuclear weapon: the Advanced Cruise Missile.

The ACM is a slender, self-guided, twenty-foot-long nuclear bullet enhanced by Stealth technology. It is the first black weapon ever subjected to scrutiny by the General Accounting Office (GAO), which conducts audits of federal programs for Congress. The auditors concluded that the ACM was a \$7 billion debacle. The weapon has flunked more than a third of its tests so far. Les Aspin, the Wisconsin Democrat who chairs the House Armed Services Committee, calls it a "disaster."

The disasters in the black budget usually stay secret. The likelihood of their coming to light is slim. Today more than 100 multimillion- and multibillion-dollar black weapons systems are being built. The secret weapons take shape in windowless buildings surrounded by fences topped with razor wire, behind doors with coded locks, guarded by armed sentries and German shepherds.

The Pentagon – which unblinkingly buys bargains such as \$436 claw hammers and \$9606 wrenches from its favorite contractors – argues that these black programs are better managed, more efficient and less susceptible to fraud than unclassified programs.

Nonsense, says Frank Conahan, who runs the GAO's national-security division. "I don't see that they're any better managed," he says. "We find the same problems in the black world as exist in the other programs. The only difference between the two is the degree to which things are kept from public debate."

If the black and white worlds of military contracting are run at similar levels of integrity, then cost overruns and corporate crimes are occurring in secret. We are

told to take it on faith that military contractors working under cover of the black budget would never abuse that protection. Given the colorful legal and financial histories of the biggest black contractors, this is a lot to ask.

Consider their records: Lockheed, whose Missile and Space division is building the MILSTAR satellites, has a rap sheet that includes bribery of foreign officials. Rockwell International was fined \$5.5 million last year for criminal fraud against the United States Air Force. General Electric has twice been convicted of committing criminal fraud against the Pentagon and has been fined \$11 million. Hughes Aircraft, a frequent CIA contractor, and Boeing, the biggest subcontractor on the Stealth bomber, have both admitted stealing top-secret Pentagon plans. Northrop, the builder of the Stealth, paid a \$17 million fine in February for criminal fraud in its work on nuclear missiles and fighter jets.

Common sense and federal regulations suggest that the government should not be handing out secret billion-dollar contracts to corporate felons. The Defense Department says it must: Our national security depends on it.

THE EXPLOSION IN SECRET SPENDING UNDER REAGAN and Bush has created an underground Pentagon, a subterranean world kept separate from the legal system. The secrecy has spread like an eclipse, obscuring more and more of the Pentagon's spending. Today about one-quarter of every dollar the Pentagon spends on new weapons is shielded by the black budget.

Members of Congress say the Pentagon uses secrecy as a weapon to control political power over the defense budget. "They control what the Congress gets and sees," says Congressman Denny Smith, an Oregon Republican, veteran fighter pilot and self-styled "cheap hawk," a cost-conscious conservative on defense issues. "They don't want to have us mucking around in their budget."

"There's a real question here," says Smith. "Will the military accept civilian leadership when it comes to choosing weapons?"

If that seems like a strange question to be asking in a constitutional democracy, it damned well should.

You have to account to the government for every dollar on your taxes, but it will not account to you for a dime of the black budget. This is not what the men who wrote the Constitution had in mind. During the debates over the Constitution's language more than 200 years ago, Patrick Henry of Virginia said a free people could not "allow the national wealth . . . to be disposed of under the veil of secrecy." His fellow Virginian George Mason said the people had "a right to know the expenditures of their money." This elegant idea, the right to know, was the source of democracy's power.

The black budget bears no relation to what we are taught in school about how laws are made and funds appropriated. The Constitution says the government must print an accurate account of how it spends our taxes. Its words are plain: "A regular Statement and Account of the Receipts and Expenditures of all public Money shall be published." That language leaves no room for a secret budget.

The black budget simply doesn't meet the Constitution's standard of accountability. It wasn't meant to.

The black budget is a creature of the cold war, and the cold war revolutionized the way in which the American government spent its money to achieve its goals. It created "a new culture" in this country, said the former senator Mike Gravel, Democrat of Alaska, "a national security culture, protected from the influences of American life by the shield of secrecy."

The war against the Soviets demanded new weapons wielded by secret agents, shielded by secret budgets. The

Common sense suggests that the federal government should not be handing out secret billion-dollar contracts to corporate felons.

culture of secrecy came into its own when Congress created the CIA. The black budget was conceived to conceal the CIA's secret wars. In short order, that shield became a sword. The secret forces created to fight communism abroad evolved into a power that challenged constitutional government at home.

IN 1949, AS THE COLD WAR BEGAN, CONGRESS CREATED the black budget by giving the CIA unlimited, unaudited, unaccountable funds buried in the Pentagon's accounts. That made the CIA, the president's secret army, immune to outside control.

By 1975 the CIA's closet was so full of skeletons that they came tumbling out in an avalanche: The Agency had been spying on Americans, infiltrating church groups and college organizations, penetrating the press and manipulating the news, opening citizens' mail and poring over their tax returns. It had fixed elections in democratic nations, hired assassins to kill foreign leaders and overthrown freely elected governments by force.

Congress realized it had no idea what the CIA was doing at home or abroad. It was forced to grapple with the "unacknowledged contradiction between the old tradition of intelligence and the Constitution," said William Colby, CIA director from 1973 to 1975. Our secret armies, raised with secret funds, threatened our own ideals. The struggle to solve this contradiction took two courses.

From 1975 to 1977, a presidential commission, a Senate investigative committee and the new Senate intelligence committee resolved, by turns, that Congress should seek to unveil the black budget, that secret spending was unconstitutional and that the United States should reveal a single sum showing what it spent on intelligence, to reflect "the qualities that distinguish our democracy from all other nations." The strongest voice against this call for *glasnost* in American government came from the man who succeeded Colby as CIA director: George Bush. By the time Reagan and Bush were elected in 1980, the era of reform was fading, and secrecy's power prevailed. The black budget remained.

That year, after long struggle and hard compromise, Congress created new guidelines for covert action and new laws to enforce them. The White House agreed to these principles. The president could no longer order his clandestine forces to topple governments or run guns to foreign lands without telling at least a few members of Congress. He would be held accountable. The president could not use secrecy to avoid the law. Those were the rules.

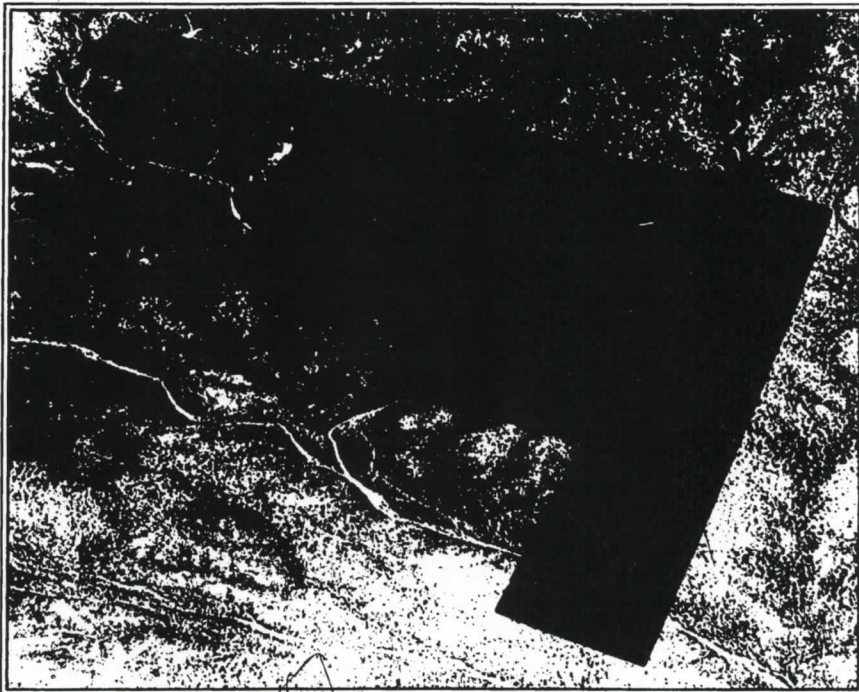
Reagan and his CIA director, William Casey, broke every one.

The president and his staff cut deals with foreign monarchs, dictators and terrorists for cash, weapons and mercenaries to carry out their secret foreign policies. The White House warjacks stocked a secret arsenal of weapons to sell to Iran and ship to the *contras*. The off-the-books cache of guns and money they created was the quintessence of the black budget.

The military men who executed the president's policies, Oliver North and John Poindexter, stretched the law to its breaking point, and Reagan broke his constitutional oath to take care that the laws be faithfully executed. The president's men argued in Congress and the courts that secrecy and lying are indispensable tools of foreign policy. They proved only that when government works in secret, it strays all too often outside laws and constitutional restraints.

And that leads to plans and policies that frighten even hardened veterans of secret wars. Clair George, the CIA's director of covert operations under Reagan, once testified to a kind of mania that grips men empowered by secrecy. "If you were ever on any given day to

THE SOLID-GOLD BOMBER



THE STEALTH BOMBER — THE WONDER WEAPON for World War III — is a monument to the costs of secrecy.

The Stealth is the most expensive airplane ever built, and its price is growing by the week.

The best guess nowadays is that each one will cost close to \$900 million. At that price the

United States Air Force could have built the seventy-ton Stealth out of solid gold, mounted it on a bed of platinum and displayed it at the National Air and Space Museum.

The batwing nuclear bomber went through ten years of clandestine research and development before it was unveiled in November 1988. In the beginning, when only four members of Congress were granted permission to know the barest details of the Stealth, the air force was telling them it could produce 132 of the bombers for roughly \$30 billion.

The cost grew in secret over the years. The Pentagon deemed public discussion of the Stealth an act of treason. By the time the black-budget shroud was lifted, and the Pentagon permitted debate on the Stealth's mission, on why it was needed, on what it might cost, it was far too late. The program could not be aborted.

Today that \$30 billion is down the tubes, and the air force has a single bomber to show for it. It wants to build seventy-four more. It says it can bring them in for another \$35 billion or so.

According to the air force, the Stealth will appear to be no bigger than an insect on Soviet radar as it drops its nuclear bombs on Soviet mobile missiles and destroys the Soviet leadership in its bunkers. An impressive technological feat — except for a few inescapable facts. We don't want to drop nuclear bombs on the Soviet Union. And if we did, the Stealth would only make the rubble bounce. Its sole

mission is to mop up on the day after Armageddon. Slower than the red-eye from Los Angeles, the bomber would hit Red Square long after thousands of warheads launched from our missile silos and submarines had reduced all Russia to a smoking, radiating ruin.

The air force argues that we need the Stealth to strike fear in the hearts of the Soviets, to stop them from launching a nuclear war against us. The problem with this rationale is that almost no one still thinks the Soviet Union has any intention whatsoever of starting a nuclear war.

"The likelihood of all-out conflict between the U.S. and the Soviet Union," says Defense Secretary Dick Cheney, "is probably lower now than it's been at just about any time since the end of World War II." So be it, and thank God. But that means the Stealth, for all its twenty-first-century technology, is an anachronism, doomed to gather dust.

Still we continue to build the Stealth and many more components of the nuclear-war machine. These massive projects, christened and launched in secrecy, become great ships churning through dark seas full speed ahead. Their course is not easily reversed. We keep creating these weapons as if in a dream, unable to free ourselves from the fears of the last fifty years.

One of the last great beasts of the cold war, the Stealth exists today because the Pentagon concealed its birth and growth behind the shield of national security. From the moment the Stealth bomber began to be stripped of its secrecy — once it became visible on the public radar screen — it was revealed as an act of folly: a war machine we cannot afford, with a mission we cannot carry out. Lacking a mission, the Stealth deserves no more money. The cost of the Stealth, and the secrecy that has surrounded it, is a real threat to the nation, a danger now greater than the Communist menace the bomber was built to destroy.

— T.W.